

GOP-led panels dig into deadly boat strike

Bipartisan House, Senate efforts to scrutinize lethal Sept. 2 Caribbean attack

BY VICTORIA BISSET, ALEX HORTON, ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND NOAH ROBERTSON

Republican-led committees in the Senate and the House say they will amplify their scrutiny of the Pentagon after a Washington Post report revealing that Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth gave a spoken order to kill all crew members aboard a vessel suspected of smuggling drugs in the Caribbean Sea several weeks ago.

A live drone feed showed two survivors from the original crew of 11 clinging to the wreckage of their boat after the initial missile attack Sept. 2, The Post reported Friday afternoon. The Special Operations commander overseeing the operation then ordered a second strike to comply with Hegseth's directive, according to two people with direct knowledge of the operation, killing both survivors. Those people, along with five others in the original report, spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the matter's sensitivity.

Late Friday, Sen. Roger Wicker (R-Mississippi), the chairman of the Senate Armed Services Committee, and Sen. Jack Reed (Rhode Island), the committee's top Democrat, issued a statement saying that the committee "is aware of recent news reports — and the Department of Defense's initial response — regarding alleged follow-on strikes on suspected narcotics vessels." The committee, they said, "has directed inquiries to the Department, and we will be conducting vigorous oversight to determine the facts related to these circumstances."

The leaders of the House Armed Services Committee, Rep. Mike D. Rogers (R-Alabama) and Rep. Adam Smith (D-Washington), followed suit late Saturday. In a brief joint statement, the pair said they are "taking bipartisan action to gather a full accounting of the operation in question." The committee, they noted, is "committed to providing rigorous

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'We won't win this war without women'

Ukraine's all-female drone unit stakes its place in a male-dominated military



OKSANA PARAFENIUK/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

From left, Maryna, Tetiana, Daria, Viktoriia and Oleksandra in Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia region in early October. They are the members of a newly created all-women crew in the Ukrainian national guard that recently achieved its first successful drone strike.

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY, KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV AND OKSANA PARAFENIUK

ZAPORIZHZHIA REGION, UKRAINE — The Ukrainian soldiers sat huddled in their dark dugout, all focus and nerve — Viktoriia's eyes shifting frantically between two screens, Tetiana's hands clutching a drone controller.

In the fields beyond, a Russian howitzer was firing shells at Ukrainian positions. The women steered their explosive-packed drone toward it and dived.

Their screens blurred. The room went quiet. Then came the voice of their commander, Daria, from the trench outside: "There was a hit!"

The troops erupted in excitement: This was their first strike since they began fighting as an all-women's crew this summer.

Nearly four years into Russia's invasion, women here are increasingly taking on combat roles once reserved for men. Ukraine's struggle to source personnel has forced its military to change. By early this year, more than 70,000 women had enlisted in Ukraine's military — up 20 percent since 2022. About 5,500 of those currently serve in combat roles.

But Daria's crew is the first in Ukraine's national guard to operate entirely without

men.

She and the four women under her command drive their own vehicle, carry their own equipment, build their own explosives and launch armed drones along the southeastern front.

When Russia first invaded Ukraine in 2014, such an arrangement would have been impossible.

Women were officially banned from

SEE UKRAINE ON A12

Peril for Zelensky: Leader faces a raft of crises as U.S. presses him to strike deal. **A14**

Trump tightens vise on Maduro

CAUTIONS AIRLINES TO AVOID AIRSPACE

Move can be precursor to land strikes in Venezuela

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, TARA COPP, VICTORIA BISSET AND SAMANTHA SCHMIDT

PALM BEACH, FLA. — President Donald Trump on Saturday said that commercial airlines should consider Venezuelan airspace closed, increasing pressure on the country's leadership after weeks of escalating tensions between Washington and Caracas and the growing threat of a U.S. attack against the country.

Though Trump does not have the legal authority to close the airspace over another country, such a move is sometimes a first step ahead of airstrikes. His declaration follows a massive buildup of U.S. military forces in the region in recent weeks, as Trump has ramped up threats against Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. And it is likely to disrupt the lives of Venezuelan citizens and the mountainous country's economy.

"To all Airlines, Pilots, Drug Dealers, and Human Traffickers, please consider THE AIRSPACE ABOVE AND SURROUNDING VENEZUELA TO BE CLOSED IN ITS ENTIRETY," Trump posted on Truth Social early Saturday.

The White House did not immediately respond to a request to explain why Trump was warning planes not to fly above Venezuela.

The Maduro government, which in recent weeks has ordered a massive mobilization of troops in response to Trump's threats, described Trump's directive as "a new extravagant, illegal, and unjustified aggression against the people of Venezuela."

"Venezuela will not accept orders, threats, or interference from any foreign power," the Maduro government said in an Instagram post on Saturday afternoon. "No authority outside the Venezuelan

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Bracing for attack: Venezuelans are living moment to moment. **A16**

TOM STOPPARD 1937-2025

Leading playwright blended the philosophical and farcical

BY FRED A. BERNSTEIN

Tom Stoppard, a Czech-born British dramatist whose intellectually challenging and verbally dazzling works included some of the most acclaimed and oft-performed plays of the past half-century, has died at his home in Dorset, England. He was 88.

United Agents, which represented Mr. Stoppard, announced his death Nov. 29 but did not state a cause.

Mr. Stoppard's most popular works — among them his Tony Award-winning plays "Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead," "Travesties," "The Real Thing," "The Coast of Utopia" trilogy and "Leopoldstadt" — explored political, artistic and scientific questions, often in settings that permitted mash-ups of high

and low culture. Topics included Fermat, Pink Floyd and Sigmund Freud, and even his most demanding works were filigreed with comic flourishes.

In "Travesties" (1974), a British envoy stages an Oscar Wilde play in Zurich with a group of drunken louts who turn out to be the Russian revolutionary Vladimir Lenin, Irish novelist James Joyce and the Dadaist poet Tristan Tzara, all of whom had been in the Swiss city in 1917.

His characters tended to debate, but rarely solve, philosophical problems. He once told television host Charlie Rose that he became a playwright because he was undecided about most issues and that constructing dialogue, with characters taking opposite points of view, "is the best way to

SEE STOPPARD ON A11



Tom Stoppard



2013 PHOTO BY WOLFGANG KAEHLER/LIGHTROCKET/GETTY IMAGES

For some Latinas, braids with ribbons take on hue of protest

The colorful practice with roots in Indigenous Mexican culture emerges as a show of resistance

BY RACHEL HATZIPANAGOS

Colorful ribbons in the red and green colors of the Mexican flag weaved into twin braids have emerged as a new symbol of resistance among some Latinas.

Dulce Flores and Angie Portillo said they felt under siege earlier this year as armed and masked federal agents fanned out across Los Angeles and other U.S. cities to conduct immigration raids.

They began wearing their hair in two long braids, with colorful ribbons woven throughout, a traditional style they were sometimes embarrassed by as children.

The style — easily identifiable within Latino culture — felt like

a "beautiful way to protest," Portillo said. Rather than trying to hide their heritage, they would embrace it.

"For Latinos, braiding has always meant something deeper," Flores, 28, said. "It represents care and patience, love and strength and resilience."

Other women began weaving ribbons into their braids and posting tutorials on TikTok. Flores and Portillo hosted braiding events called "Ponte Your Moños," which loosely translates in a mixture of English and Spanish to "get your hair ready" or "get up and move."

After wearing red, white and green ribbon braids at a sold-out Orlando concert, rapper Reverie

SEE RIBBONS ON A7

A woman with colorful braids in Teotitlan del Valle, a small town near the city of Oaxaca, in southern Mexico.

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Ohio State caps a 12-0 regular season with a win vs. rival Michigan. **B1**

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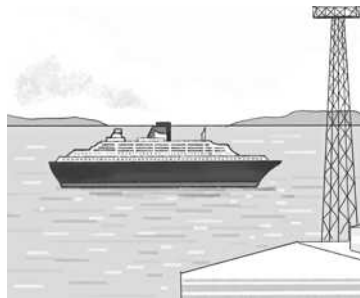


THE WORLD

In his first trip abroad as pope, Leo XIV speaks less than he listens. **A15**

ARTS & STYLE

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